SCIENTIFIC PAPER FORENSICS
RETROSPECTIVE DOSSIER / 04 NOVEMBER 2026

Brownian motion, before diffusion.

A critical experimental audit of Huang et al. (2011)

Direct observation of the full transition from ballistic to diffusive Brownian motion in a liquid

PAPER
R. Huang et al. | Nature Physics 7, 576-580 (2011)
doi:10.1038/nphys1953

Evidence-first / Figure-by-figure audit / Retrospective validation

Executive verdict

Verdict: a landmark observation enabled by exceptional position-detection engineering, with important limits to the scope of the 'direct' claim. This work decisively moved experimental Brownian-motion tracking of a single micron-scale sphere in water into the inertial regime. Its particularly compelling evidence is a *three-way concurrence*: an approximately quadratic short-time mean-square displacement (MSD); a mass-density effect between equal-diameter polystyrene and silica spheres; and a velocity autocorrelation function (VACF) incompatible with a conventional memoryless Langevin treatment but consistent with particle-and-fluid inertia. The enabling achievement was a high-bandwidth optical-interferometric detector, not the discovery of ballistic dynamics or hydrodynamic memory, both theoretically anticipated and partly observed earlier.

The headline limitation: the 2011 study did **not** record sufficiently smooth, low-noise individual position trajectories to determine an instantaneous velocity distribution. Its MSD and VACF are ensemble/time-averaged statistical estimators, and the underlying calibration invokes the hydrodynamic theory that the data are then said to verify. The same-size/different-density test reduces that circularity but does not eliminate systematic questions about optical response and spectral noise. The paper itself acknowledges that direct Maxwell-distribution measurement remained beyond its apparatus (page 578).

Retrospectively, the short-time inertial regime has stood up: later independent or partially independent measurements of hydrodynamic-memory signatures, together with more decisive *same-research-lineage* liquid-phase instantaneous-velocity experiments, support the underlying physics. A fully independent, like-for-like reproduction of the **entire** 2011 10-ns-to-1-ms result, including its precise shortest-lag correction, was not established by the sources inspected here. **Overall: strong phenomenon-level credibility; exact-instrument replication and some detector-noise assumptions remain open.**

1. Claim hierarchy: observation versus inference

Principal assertion	Direct measurement and paper location	Epistemic status	Retrospective assessment
Single particle crosses ballistic to diffusive dynamics in liquid	Interferometric lateral position traces; MSD, Fig. 2, p. 577	Direct time-series observable; ballistic label is a dynamical interpretation	Strong, especially as accompanied by Fig. 3 density control
Short-lag MSD tends toward t^2	1 and 2.5 μm silica, Fig. 2; normalization Fig. 3b	Derived correlation statistic with a subtraction of detector noise	Strong qualitative signature; closest-lag magnitude needs an aliasing/noise budget
Particle inertia alters motion independent of radius	2.5 μm silica vs polystyrene, Fig. 3a	Mechanism inferred from density-controlled contrast	Stronger discriminating test than t^2 alone; residual optical/material differences possible
Hydrodynamic memory is quantitatively necessary	VACF versus Clercx–Schram and simple Langevin models, Fig. 4	Theory comparison, conditional on calibration/model	Strong evidence against memoryless Langevin for these parameters

Principal assertion	Direct measurement and paper location	Epistemic status	Retrospective assessment
Particle's individual instantaneous speed is measured	Not shown; paper explicitly says individual traces remain insufficient	**Not claimed as achieved** in the article's careful discussion	First liquid-phase Maxwell-distribution tests appeared later
Compressible-fluid acoustic regime verified	No; τc and sub-picometer limits are discussed on p. 579	Explicit untested prediction	Remains outside the 2011 measurement scope

Measurement chain: trap a dilute sphere in water → forward laser-scattering interferometry → two fiber-fed photodiodes operated as a balanced position detector → digitize position at 100 MHz → estimate MSD and VACF → compare with hydrodynamic-memory models → infer inertial regimes. The theory enters not only the interpretation but also radius/position-calibration fitting.

2. NABC: Need, Approach, Benefits, Competition

At publication (2011)

Need. Einstein's diffusive description correctly describes long-lag displacements but hides meaningful instantaneous velocity below the particle's momentum-relaxation time. Early work had found hydrodynamic deviations, yet the approximately 100 ns timescale and tens-of-picometer displacements for a 1 μm silica sphere in water made a direct liquid-phase ballistic test difficult [Lukić, *Phys. Rev. Lett.*, 2005; Li, *Science*, 2010].

Approach. Hold a single bead far from walls in a 1,064 nm, 600 mW optical trap; collect forward interferometric signals with fibers feeding small fast photodiodes; use a 75 MHz nominal detection bandwidth and high-rate digitization; measure MSD and VACF across many time lags [Huang, *Nat. Phys.*, 2011, Methods].

Benefits. A reported MSD noise-subtracted limit of ~0.0005 nm² at roughly 10 ns (an inferred displacement scale of ~20–22 pm), density-sensitive inertial dynamics, and a VACF exposing fluid-memory effects. These are *correlation sensitivities*, not single-frame, absolute, 20-pm localization accuracy.

Competition. Earlier interferometric particle tracking measured nondiffusive *hydrodynamic* correlations but did not fully resolve particle ballistic behavior in liquid [Lukić, *Phys. Rev. Lett.*, 2005]. Li and collaborators had directly measured the instantaneous velocity of a trapped sphere in a rarefied gas, where drag is much lower, but this was not an equivalent liquid benchmark [Li, *Science*, 2010]. Dynamic and diffusing-wave light scattering constrained collective or time-averaged motion at different conditions; none offered this exact single-bead liquid ballistic measurement with the same optical geometry.

Retrospective (2026)

Need. The frontier has shifted from demonstrating ballistic scaling to resolving non-Markovian forces, near-wall hydrodynamics, conditioned velocity trajectories, liquid compressibility and high-frequency rheological response.

Approach/benefits. Inertial particle tracking is now a methodological lineage encompassing direct liquid-phase velocity distributions, calibrated high-frequency optical tweezers and conditional trajectories. Results in 2014–2015 achieved modified equipartition/Maxwell statistics in liquid; 2026 work probed conditioned trajectories with t^(5/2) MSD scaling [Kheifets, *Science*, 2014; Mo, *Opt. Express*, 2015; Boynewicz, *Sci. Adv.*, 2026].

Competition. For routine viscosity or low-frequency microrheology, standard bead-tracking and power-spectrum approaches are simpler. High-bandwidth back-focal-plane interferometry remains distinctive when nano/microsecond fluid inertia is the target, but it requires specialized detectors, optics, and careful alias/noise calibration. The 2011 instrument is a compelling research platform, not a demonstrated commercial particle sensor.

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3. Conceptual breakthrough and enabling technology

Breakthrough class: enabling experimental capability and stringent physical-theory test, not a new fundamental explanation. Langevin's particle-inertia description was established in 1908; hydrodynamic memory and non-exponential VACFs were developed by Vladimirsky, Hinch and later Clercx–Schram [Hinch, *J. Fluid Mech.*, 1975; Clercx, *Phys. Rev. A*, 1992]. The 2005 predecessor already recorded nondiffusive motion, and the 2010 gas-phase experiment verified velocity equipartition under easier dynamical conditions.

The essential innovation was the **combination** of optical-trap interferometry, a fiber-coupled fast balanced detector, aggressive high-rate sampling, and careful averaged correlation statistics. No single element independently proved ballistic behavior: the 2008 detector-development work was a direct technological precursor [Chavez, *Rev. Sci. Instrum.*, 2008]. Particle selection (silica, polystyrene, melamine resin) was not a novel material discovery but created discriminating checks across mass and signal strength. The scientific gain came from integrating detection and experimental design to bridge a bandwidth-versus-displacement gap.

Crucially, the full physical description is **not** an abrupt two-state switch. Hydrodynamic memory produces a continuous crossover between m*-controlled t^2 and Einstein's 2Dt, and trapping eventually causes a plateau. In the earliest accessible regime, the 'effective' inertial mass includes half the displaced liquid mass for an incompressible spherical-flow model.

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4. Figure-by-figure experimental critique

Figure 1 — Detector geometry (p. 577)

Question: How can a micrometer-size sphere's motion be tracked at exceptionally short times? **Measurement:** a schematic of optical trapping and fiber-coupled differential detection; $x \propto I_1 - I_2$. **Direct support:** physical layout and the sign-sensitive interferometric position readout. **Not demonstrated by the figure:** transfer-function linearity, frequency response, detector shot-noise budget, temperature stability or a full anti-alias filter response. A calibration by moving the bead with an independent piezo displacement and measuring detector response against frequency would clarify the usable bandwidth.

Figure 2 — Mean-square displacement and ballistic-looking scaling (p. 577)

Question: Does a single trapped bead exhibit t^2 rather than 2Dt at ultrashort times? **Observable:** 100 MHz position traces over 40 ms, yielding noise-corrected MSDs for 1 and 2.5 µm silica spheres. **Result:** roughly quadratic earliest-lag growth, a hydrodynamic crossover, then a trap-limited plateau near 10^{-4} s. **Control:** a bead-free optical measurement subtracted as an MSD noise floor; blocking estimates uncertainty in correlated samples. **Concern:** 100 MHz digitization has a 50 MHz Nyquist frequency, below the nominal 75 MHz detector analog bandwidth. The article does not document a full anti-alias transfer-function/noise spectral analysis. Background subtraction also assumes the no-bead noise is equivalent to bead-in-trap noise. The sub-10-ns scale cannot be inferred from the nominal 75 MHz alone.

Falsification: vary sample rate (e.g. 100 versus 200 MHz), impose verified low-pass filters, vary trap laser power, and compare measured short-lag MSD before/after deconvolution; the inertial curve should remain stable after a calibrated transfer correction.

Figure 3a — Same radius, different density (p. 578)

Question: Is the short-lag signal truly particle inertia rather than generic optical/electronic smoothing? **Observable:** normalized MSD for 2.5 µm silica (1.96 g mL^{-1}) and polystyrene (1.05 g mL^{-1}) spheres with a common hydrodynamic timescale $\tau f \approx 1.6$ µs. **Result:** long-lag curves converge; the short-lag data separate, approaching a roughly twofold difference near the resolution limit. **Strength:** density changes the expected inertial mass while the radius and fluid are held similar. **Concern:** optical refractive index, detector conversion factor, particle-size dispersity and trap stiffness also change with composition. The most decisive control would use two near-index-matched materials with known density and independently measured geometry/calibration.

Figure 3b — Approach to the ballistic asymptote (p. 578)

Question: Are measured displacements consistent with the hydrodynamic effective mass? **Observable:** MSD divided by $(kBT/m^*)t^2$ for two silica diameters. **Result:** the larger particle reaches about 90% of the ballistic asymptote; the smaller does not reach an equally clean asymptote at the available resolution. **Strength:** correct size trend and approach to a parameter-predicted limit. **Limit:** 90% is an approach, not a direct observation of a perfectly constant-velocity, free segment. The transformation can visually magnify the importance of the shortest-lag correction.

Figure 4 — Velocity autocorrelation function (p. 578)

Question: Can measured velocity correlations distinguish hydrodynamic-memory models from ordinary Langevin dynamics? **Observable:** velocities computed from position traces, averaged over 100 records/segments from a 2 µm resin sphere in a 280 pN μm^{-1} trap. **Result:** the Clercx–Schram prediction closely follows the data, including the trap-related anti-correlation, where ordinary Langevin curves deviate at short times. **Strength:** the VACF interrogates different features of the same position dynamics and compares both models with and without trapping. **Concern:** differentiation amplifies electronic noise; the Methods mention 50 MHz acquisition smoothed to 5 MHz, which removes some fastest modes. Figure caption refers to 80 ms per segment while Methods say 40 ms traces. Clarifying the acquisition length, filter transfer function and confidence bands is warranted. No exponent-fit establishing a $t^{-3/2}$ tail independently from the full model is provided.

Falsification: publish unfiltered and filter-corrected VACFs from raw recordings; pre-register the hydrodynamic prediction using independently determined bead diameter, density, viscosity and trap stiffness; compare out-of-sample residuals versus a flexible colored-noise alternative.

5. Quantitative audit and physical sanity checks

For a spherical particle of radius r, particle density ρp, fluid density ρf, and dynamic viscosity η:

- Stokes friction $\gamma = 6\pi\eta r$.
- Particle mass $m = (4\pi/3)\rho_p r^3$; displaced fluid mass $m_f = (4\pi/3)\rho_f r^3$.
- Incompressible-flow effective mass $m^* = m + \tfrac{1}{2}m_f$.
- Particle momentum-relaxation time $\tau_p = m/\gamma = 2\rho_p r^2/(9\eta)$.
- Hydrodynamic fluid-vorticity time $\tau_f = \rho_f r^2/\eta$, so $\tau_f/\tau_p = 9\rho_f/(2\rho_p)$.
- Ballistic one-axis MSD $\approx (kBT/m^*)t^2$; late free one-axis MSD $= 2Dt$ with $D = kBT/\gamma$.

Independent arithmetic, assuming the article's values T = 296 K, $\eta = 10^{-3}$ Pa s, $\rho_f = 1000$ kg m^{-3} and silica $\rho_p = 1960$ kg m^{-3}:

Audited parameter	1.0 µm silica sphere	2.5 µm silica sphere
Radius r	0.50 µm	1.25 µm
Particle mass m	1.03×10^{-15} kg	1.60×10^{-14} kg
Effective mass m*	1.29×10^{-15} kg	2.01×10^{-14} kg
Friction γ	9.42×10^{-9} kg s^{-1}	2.36×10^{-8} kg s^{-1}
$\tau_p = m/\gamma$	0.109 µs	0.681 µs
$\tau_f = r^2\rho_f/\eta$	0.250 µs	1.563 µs
Ballistic rms speed in one axis, $\sqrt{(kBT/m^*)}$	1.78 mm s^{-1}	0.451 mm s^{-1}
Diffusion $D = kBT/\gamma$	0.434 µm^2 s^{-1}	0.173 µm^2 s^{-1}

At t = 10 ns, the ideal 1.0 µm silica ballistic formula gives MSD ≈ 0.000317 nm² and root-MSD ≈ 17.8 pm, consistent in order of magnitude with the article's quoted ~0.0005 nm² and ~20 pm figure. **This is a scale check, not an independently reconstructed experimental noise floor.** For 2.5 µm particles the predicted $\tau_p \approx 0.68$ µs and $\tau_f \approx 1.56$ µs match the labels in Fig. 3.

For equal-radius silica and polystyrene, the strict asymptotic effective-mass ratio $m_{silica}/m_{PS} = (1.96 + 0.50)/(1.05 + 0.50) \approx 1.59$, under the incompressible hydrodynamic prescription. The paper's ~2× separation at the *finite* lag $t \approx 0.07\tau_f$ is not identical to that asymptote, so it must be compared with the complete time-dependent model rather than treated as a direct mass-ratio measurement.

Bandwidth caveat: Sampling at 100 MHz yields a 10 ns sample interval and a Nyquist frequency of 50 MHz. A 75 MHz analog bandwidth, in isolation, does not guarantee alias-free 100 MHz digitization.

The 2011 data may nonetheless be accurate, but the main text does not provide enough electronics/noise detail to audit that step independently. Similarly, a quoted ~20 pm root-MSD at 10 ns reflects a corrected *statistical displacement estimator*, not necessarily a 20 pm absolute instantaneous position measurement.

6. History: precursors, corroboration and extensions

Year	Primary source	Relationship to 2011 claim	Independence and inference
1975	Hinch, *J. Fluid Mech.*	Predicts particle-fluid inertial memory and nontrivial VACF	Theoretical precursor, not experimental validation
1992	Clercx & Schram, *Phys. Rev. A*	Harmonic-trap hydrodynamic treatment	Model underlying the 2011 fit
2005	Lukić, *Phys. Rev. Lett.*	Earlier liquid nondiffusive regime; partial inertial signal	Substantial investigator overlap; not first fully ballistic test
2010	Li, *Science*	Direct instantaneous velocity of optically trapped sphere in *gas*	Related team; distinct physical medium
2011	Huang, *Nat. Phys.*	Short-time liquid MSD + VACF + density-control demonstration	Anchor experiment
2011	Franosch, *Nature*	Hydrodynamic-memory resonance / colored thermal-noise spectrum	Separate experiment, overlapping Sylvia Jeney authorship; corroborates memory, not identical 10 ns MSD
2012	Grimm, *Phys. Rev. E*	High-bandwidth calibration using memory-aware MSD and VACF	Overlapping Jeney group; methodological extension
2014	Kheifets, *Science*	Hydrodynamic instantaneous velocity and anticorrelated thermal force in liquid	Raizen lineage; stronger direct measurement, not independent replication
2015	Mo, *Opt. Express*	Modified Maxwell–Boltzmann velocity distribution in liquid	Raizen lineage; validates key prediction with higher directness
2015	Mo, *Phys. Rev. E*	Ballistic Brownian dynamics near a wall	Same lineage; extension to confined geometry
2019	Paul, *Soft Matter*	Independently examines hydrodynamically coupled non-Markovian motion in optical traps	Different lab, different two-particle/time-scale regime; *not* like-for-like replication
2026	Boynewicz, *Sci. Adv.*	Conditional-velocity selection reveals t^(5/2) super-ballistic fluctuations	Raizen lineage, different statistical ensemble; a refinement, not contradiction

Survival matrix. (1) A short-lag t^2 regime for ordinary equilibrium averages: **supported** by later tests. (2) Liquid added-mass and hydrodynamic memory: **strongly supported at the phenomenon level** by distinct experimental signatures. (3) The *exact* 2011 20 pm / 10 ns estimate and full transfer calibration: **not independently re-audited**. (4) Individual instantaneous velocity

measured in 2011: **not done**, later demonstrated elsewhere. (5) Compressibility-driven oscillatory sub-nanosecond VACF: **unresolved in the reviewed 2011 data**.

Correction and replication search: The DOI and publication record were verified against the publisher. A scite forward-citation screen and targeted searches of primary papers through November 2026 did not establish a directly matching, independently performed, full-regime reproduction. No formal correction/retraction was found in the inspected metadata, which is not proof none exists. Scite's indexed metadata on 4 November 2026 reported 459 citing publications and 388 classified citation statements (14 supportive, 0 contrasting, 371 mentioning; remainder unclassified); these classifications are database-specific and **do not establish validity or independence**.

7. Long-term influence and scientific legacy

The lasting achievement is methodological and conceptual **access**: a previously impractical window of liquid-phase dynamics became observable in an individual colloidal probe. The experiment helped push precision optical particle tracking from a diffusion-only description toward non-Markovian fluid-particle dynamics. Later work made the instantaneous-velocity distribution measurable and explored colored thermal noise, wall influence, and conditional initial-velocity ensembles. It did **not** demonstrate a deployable sensor, scalable metrology product or an experimentally verified compressible-flow acoustic crossover. Its importance should not be inflated by counting general citations about Brownian motion as precise replications of its figures.

A major scientific lesson is the dependence of 'velocity' on the measurement timescale and the coupled fluid mass: at accessible times the liquid co-moves with the bead, and the m* prediction matters; at still faster acoustic times, incompressibility and hence the simple added-mass picture can fail. The 2011 paper articulated that limitation rather than hiding it.

8. Six-dimensional scorecard (separate scores; no average)

Dimension	Score	Confidence	Rationale
Conceptual originality	**3 / 5**	High	A major new observation, but ballistic scaling, added mass and memory were predicted; 2005 liquid precursors existed.
Methodological rigor	**4 / 5**	Moderate	Multiple particle types, blank noise correction, blocking errors, trap calibration; anti-alias and theory-assisted calibration underdocumented.
Strength of experimental evidence	**4 / 5**	High	t^2 slope, density-dependent contrast and model-discriminating VACF jointly support inertia.
Performance advance	**5 / 5**	High	First convincing single-sphere liquid ballistic regime with ~10 ns correlation access.
Independent validation	**3 / 5**	Low–moderate	Distinct hydrodynamic signatures corroborated, but key follow-ups overlap investigator lineage; exact independent duplication not verified.

Dimension	Score	Confidence	Rationale
Long-term scientific impact	**4 / 5**	Moderate	Influential high-bandwidth tracking and non-Markovian microrheology research; no demonstrated industrial standard.

9. Ten demanding discussion questions and discriminating tests

Q1. Could aliasing bias the 10 ns MSD? The analog 75 MHz detector and 100 MHz digitization have different limiting frequencies. **Resolve with:** measured frequency transfer and anti-alias response, 200+ MHz cross-sampling and raw noise spectra.

Q2. Does bead-free background subtraction remove bead-dependent optical noise? Scattering, relative intensity noise and intensity-to-position conversion can be bead-specific. **Resolve with:** multi-power, multi-photodiode simultaneous noise characterization and control beads with immobilized position.

Q3. Are calibration and theoretical confirmation independent? Hinch dynamics are used to fit radius and detector scale before theory–data agreement is advertised. **Resolve with:** independently calibrated displacements, SEM diameter distributions and viscosity/temperature checks, fitting no free scale to the short-lag MSD.

Q4. Does the density test isolate mass alone? Silica and polystyrene have different refractive index, optical scattering and size dispersity. **Resolve with:** independent optical gain and geometric measurements, plus density-matched/isorefractive comparisons where feasible.

Q5. What is the model-free t^2 exponent and credible lag range? A plotted line of slope 2 is not a confidence interval. **Resolve with:** bootstrap/block-correlated local-slope confidence bands and exact noise-subtraction sensitivity.

Q6. Is the VACF evidence independent of the MSD? Both originate from the same signals, differentiation, smoothing and hydrodynamic calibration. **Resolve with:** an orthogonal interferometer or detection axis and spectral-domain FDT prediction fixed a priori.

Q7. What portion of the t^(-3/2) long-time tail is truly resolved? The trap modifies the correlations and creates anti-correlation. **Resolve with:** multiple stiffnesses, explicit exponent fits in a validated free-particle window and comparison with no-trap simulations.

Q8. How much do wall hydrodynamics and laser heating matter? The article places beads >10 diameters from a coverslip and assumes near-room-temperature water properties. **Resolve with:** measured bead axial position, in situ thermometry, wall-distance scan, and laser-power extrapolation.

Q9. What physical feature would distinguish incompressible added mass from a finite-speed acoustic response? The 2011 analysis cannot reach $\tau_c \approx 0.3$ ns for a 1 μm bead. **Resolve with:** sub-nanosecond, picometer-level dynamic tracking or a complementary high-frequency acoustic scattering measurement and a compressible-fluid model.

Q10. Can an unrelated laboratory reproduce the *same* MSD and VACF without using the original theory for calibration? Shared-lineage papers do not suffice as full external validation.

Resolve with: preregistered cross-laboratory raw data, traceable photodiode response, bead metrology, and deposited uncertainty-analysis code.

10. Final synthesis

Strongest defense: three different experimental signatures support the inertial crossover, with sample-density discrimination and VACF model comparison extending beyond visual recognition of a t^2 slope. This was a genuine and difficult precision-measurement advance.

Strongest criticism: the deepest short-time claims depend on corrected correlation estimators whose noise spectral response and calibration are incompletely independent of the theory being tested. The word 'direct' is defensible for observed dynamics but must not be read as a direct Maxwell-distributed velocity measurement.

Survived: equilibrium short-time ballistic scaling, the importance of fluid added mass and hydrodynamic memory, and the availability of particle-scale liquid inertial metrology. **Not established by this paper:** instantaneous velocity histograms, compressible-fluid τc physics, a universal sensor platform, or a fully independent exact replication.

Most decisive remaining experiment: have an unrelated laboratory make a traceable, broadband, anti-alias-verified measurement across multiple known-density, near-equal-radius beads and fluids, jointly publishing raw short-lag MSD, frequency-domain response and VACF, with independent calibration and preregistered residual tests. A faithful reproduction would elevate independent-validation confidence; a systematic density-independent discrepancy at the shortest lags would force revision of the present quantitative claim.

Final judgement: Huang et al. (2011) remains an important and credible landmark in experimental statistical mechanics because it resolved a previously inaccessible liquid-phase inertial regime; its cleanest legacy is the verified *capability to observe* that regime, with the fine-grained velocity distribution and detector/systematic questions left for later experiments.

References and evidence access

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Source/access limitations (4 November 2026): Original five-page publisher PDF was supplied and all four figures examined. No standalone supplementary-information file was provided with the source. Primary follow-ups were checked using publisher, PubMed and open full-text excerpts; their complete raw datasets were not reanalyzed. Some primary articles were abstract-only. Forward citation graph coverage is incomplete by construction; the inspected sample includes citing mentions and is not a systematic census of replication attempts. No pixel-level data extraction or independent redigitization was performed. Theory checks are analytic back-of-envelope calculations, not reproductions of the authors' fits. The original article's Fig. 4 caption and Methods appear inconsistent on 80 ms versus 40 ms acquisition; this has not been reconciled against lab records.

Direct observation of the full transition from ballistic to diffusive Brownian motion in a liquid

Huang et al. (2011) *Nature Physics* **7**, 576–580 | doi:10.1038/nphys1953

A critical retrospective of the first experimental observation of ballistic Brownian motion in a liquid using ultrafast, high-precision position tracking.

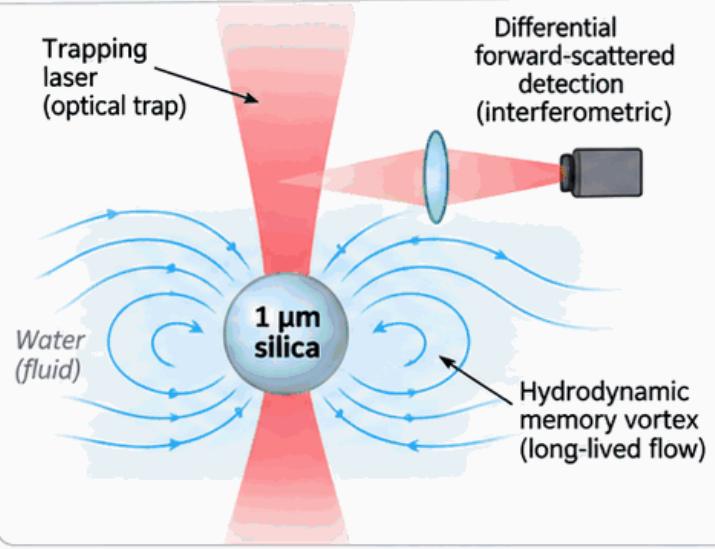
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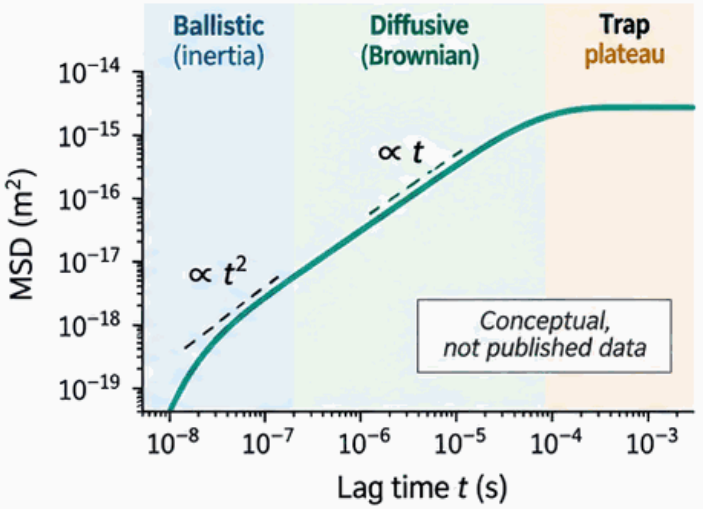
Can inertia be resolved in liquid?

BREAKTHROUGH

Ultrafast interferometric tracking

- Optical trap with interferometric detection
- 75 MHz detector bandwidth
- 100 MHz sampling rate
- ~20 pm displacement sensitivity (inferred from corrected MSD at 10 ns)
- 1–2.5 µm silica spheres in water





DIRECT EVIDENCE

- **Quadratic short-lag MSD:** MSD ∝ t^2, showing the ballistic regime.
- **Density contrast:** different short-time behavior for silica vs, polystyrene, consistent with inertia (different ρ_p).
- **Hydrodynamic VACF:** measured velocity autocorrelation function with long-time tail, consistent with hydrodynamic memory.

CRITICAL LIMIT

- Ensemble MSD/VACF, NOT an individual instantaneous velocity distribution.
- **Model-assisted** calibration (e.g., hydrodynamic corrections and effective mass).
- Aliasing/noise audit outstanding (effects on the shortest time scales not fully quantified).

LATER TESTS

- **2011 Franosch:** colored hydrodynamic noise (overlapping team).
- **2014 Kheifets:** hydrodynamic instantaneous velocities (overlapping Raizen lab).
- **2015 Mo:** modified Maxwell distribution (overlapping Raizen lab).
- **Independent exact replication not established in this review.**

SIX-DIMENSIONAL SCORECARD

Conceptual originality	3 / 5
Methodological rigor	4 / 5
Strength of experimental evidence	4 / 5
Performance advance	5 / 5
Independent validation	3 / 5
Long-term scientific impact	4 / 5

VERDICT

Convincing new instrument-enabled observation, not yet a single-shot velocity measurement.

Huang et al., Nat. Phys. **7**, 576–580 (2011) | doi:10.1038/nphys1953